

RUSSIAN WARMTH

Photographs by AP



With a year-long cultural extravaganza being kicked off and major efforts being made to boost bilateral trade, relations with Russia which had encountered some turbulence are back on an even keel

■ By Raj Chengappa

For months there has been talk of a chill developing between Russia and India on a range of issues. Much of it had to do with major delays in the delivery schedule of the re-fitted aircraft carrier *Gorshkov* that the Russians were selling India apart from a highly unreasonable demand to double its price. On the Russian side there was heartburn over India not signing the agreement to buy four nuclear reactors. There also were diplomatic gaffes that saw India's External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee unable to meet up with his counterpart in Russia

when he went last year to Moscow apart from being frisked at the airport. The long standing friendship between the two countries seemed to have encountered unexpected turbulence.

Last week, as spring set in Delhi it seemed to considerably warm the relations between the two countries. To kick off the "Year of Russia" in India, Prime Minister Viktor Zubkov flew in with an impressive entourage of over 100-top Russian businessmen and a jamboree of cultural troupes. Before he arrived he set the tone of his visit when in an interview he said, "For us, India is a trusted friend. There is a saying in Russia: One old friend is better

BONHOMIE: Zubkov (left) with Manmohan Singh in Delhi than two new ones."

Described as a working visit, the two sides made an effort to sort out outstanding issues especially the stagnant bilateral trade in the private sector. After a discussion with Zubkov, where the warmth between the two was obvious, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh said, "We have agreed to redouble our efforts to tap the full potential of our two economies. We agreed on the need to diversify our trade basket and expand co-operation in sectors such as minerals, diamonds, transport and infrastructure, investment and services and high technology."

That trade formed a major part of the discussion with busloads of top Russian businessmen descending on